

**INFLUENCE OF INTERGRATED MARKETING
COMMUNICATIONS ON STUDENT ENROLLMENT IN
NEWLY ESTABLISHED PUBLIC TVET INSTITUTIONS IN
KIAMBU COUNTY, KENYA**

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DECLARATION

Student Declaration

This research proposal is my own original work. It has not been submitted to any other institution of higher learning for examination or for any other academic award.

Signature

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Supervisors' Declaration

This research proposal has been submitted for examination with our approval as the university supervisor.

Signature..... Date.....

Dr. Edward Kobuthi

Supervisor Number:

Acknowledgement

By God's grace, I have reached this milestone.

I am sincerely grateful to my supervisor, Dr. Edward Kobuthi, for his guidance and encouragement at every stage of this work. His comments have shaped this proposal in many ways.

ABSTRACT

Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET) is widely seen as central to industrialisation and youth employment in Kenya, and it has a clear place in Kenya Vision 2030. The government has put considerable resources into the sector, both through reforms such as the TVET Act 2013 and by building new institutions across the country. Even so, many of the newly established public TVET institutions, especially in Kiambu County, still record low enrolment. Earlier studies point to two main reasons: the way society views technical training, and marketing activities that are poorly coordinated. KCSE results suggest that at least thirty thousand form four leavers in Kiambu County could join TVET each year. This does not automatically happen, and both public and private TVETs have to depend on marketing to attract trainees. It is therefore worth finding out whether a planned and coordinated communication approach makes a difference to enrolment. The purpose of this study is to examine the influence of Integrated Marketing Communications (IMC) on student enrolment in newly established public TVET institutions in Kiambu County, Kenya. The study has four specific objectives, which are to examine the influence of digital marketing, broadcast media, outdoor media and experiential outreach on student enrolment. It is anchored on the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM) and the Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB), which help to explain how technology and social and personal factors shape people's decisions. A descriptive survey design will be used, targeting students and staff of six public TVET institutions in the county. Data will be collected using questionnaires and analysed using descriptive statistics, correlation and multiple regression, after diagnostic tests have confirmed that the data meet the assumptions of regression. The study is expected to show how each IMC channel, and the channels together, contribute to enrolment. Its findings should help TVET managers, policy makers and other stakeholders to plan better multi-channel marketing campaigns, and in the long run contribute to a stronger TVET sector and to efforts against youth unemployment and skills gaps in Kenya.

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS AND ACRONYMS

Acronyms/Abbreviations

Full forms/Full Names

CAK	Communications Authority of Kenya
ECD	Early Childhood Development
ICT	Information and Communication Technology
IMC	Integrated Marketing Communication

KNBS	Kenya National Bureau of Statistics
KNEC	Kenya National Examinations Council
MOE	Ministry of Education
SDTVET Training	State Department for Technical and Vocational Education and Training
SPSS	Statistical Package for the Social Sciences
TAM	Technology Acceptance Model
TPB	Theory of Planned Behavior
TVC	Technical and Vocational College
TVET	Technical and Vocational Education and Training
VIF	Variance Inflation Factor

CHAPTER ONE INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background of the Study

In many parts of the world, TVET is now treated as an important driver of economic growth, industrialisation and job creation for young people. UNESCO and the World Bank have repeatedly stressed that TVET gives learners practical skills that match the changing needs of the labour market (UNESCO, 2022). In a number of developed countries, TVET institutions no longer simply offer courses and wait for applicants; they run planned promotional campaigns across several channels to keep their numbers up and secure their future.

In Kenya, the role of TVET is set out in Kenya Vision 2030, which sees the reform of technical training as a key driver of industrialisation and economic development. The sector is expected to equip workers with the technical, industrial and business skills that a modern economy needs (Government of Kenya, 2007). Over the last ten years, the government has pursued this goal through several reforms, including the TVET Act of 2013, the move to Competency-Based Education and Training (CBET) and the construction of public TVET institutions in every sub-county. Under the Ministry of Education, these reforms have aimed to widen access, improve training facilities and strengthen quality assurance (Ministry of Education, 2021). The expansion shows a clear policy wish to make technical education a respected route to employment. Such spending, however, can only be justified if young people take up the training, and this is seen in the numbers enrolled. It is for this reason that TVET institutions in Kiambu County have been marketing themselves, hoping to raise their enrolment and serve more people in the county. Marketing can be understood both as a social process and as a management activity in which value is created and exchanged to meet customer needs. Kotler and Armstrong (2012) describe it as the science and art of exploring, creating and delivering value to satisfy a target market at a profit. This value is communicated through several channels, each reaching people differently. Digital marketing builds personal relationships online, broadcast media reaches large audiences, outdoor media keeps a brand visible in a particular area, and experiential outreach creates personal connections that last (Kotler and Keller, 2016). Much of today's education marketing brings these channels together under an Integrated Marketing Communications (IMC) approach. When a college coordinates its digital marketing (websites, social media and bulk SMS), broadcast media (radio and television adverts or talk shows), outdoor media (billboards and banners) and community outreach (roadshows and school visits), it sends one consistent message. Handling the channels as one connected system, and not as separate activities, can improve how the public sees TVET, increase engagement with prospective students and make marketing more effective, which in turn raises enrolment (World Bank, 2020).

KCSE results show that there is a large and growing need for alternatives to university. Most secondary school leavers fall within the group that technical training is meant to serve. In 2023, out of 899,453 candidates, 698,320 scored a C plain or below and only 201,133 scored C+ or above. In 2024, out of 962,512 candidates, 716,121 scored C or below while 246,391 reached the university entry grade. In 2025, the number scoring C and below rose to 722,511 out of 993,226 candidates, while 270,715 scored C+ and above. Every year, therefore, more than 70% of candidates fall into this group, and these school leavers will make up a large part of Kenya's future workforce.

Table 1 National KCSE Candidates Performance Data

Year	Total Candidature	C+ and Above	C and Below
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2023	899,453	201,133	698,320
2024	962,512	246,391	716,121
2025	993,226	270,715	722,511

These numbers show how many young people the TVET sector could train and empower each year, which makes the performance of technical institutions an important social and economic matter. Yet enrolment in many public TVET institutions across Kenya is still well below capacity. One of the most persistent problems is the negative view of vocational training in society (Ngure, 2023). For many years, TVET has been seen as a fallback for learners who fail to get a university place, and this view still influences the choices of young people and of the parents and guardians who pay their fees (Oketch, 2024). So, even where modern workshops have been built and flexible modular courses introduced, many colleges find it hard to attract enough students. The gap between what policy intends and what is happening to enrolment raises questions about how well current promotional efforts work and how well they are coordinated. It suggests that occasional publicity events are not enough, and that colleges need well-planned and coordinated communication that can challenge old attitudes and change how the public sees technical training.

The figure below shows KSCE Candidature in Kiambu County:

Going by the figures for these two years, about thirty thousand young people in Kiambu County could join TVET every year.

Table 2 Kiambu County KCSE performance data

YEAR	2024	2025
MALE	18177	18749
FEMALE	20848	21469
TOTAL CANDIDATURE	39025	40218
C+ AND ABOVE	8806	9311
BELOW C+	30219	30907

With such numbers, one would expect every TVET institution in Kiambu to fill its classes without difficulty. There are also thousands of out-of-school young people under 30 who are

neither in training nor in work, and all of them could join a TVET institution. In practice, though, both public and private TVETs have to market themselves heavily to get students. The problem is greater in a competitive and fast-growing county like Kiambu. The newly established public colleges, namely Lari, Githunguri, Ruiru, Limuru, Gatundu and Nachu Technical and Vocational Colleges, are in a difficult position. They have to build a new name while competing for the same local students with older institutions that are well known and trusted. In the county, the new colleges operate alongside large public institutions such as Thika Technical Training Institute and Kiambu National Polytechnic, as well as active private colleges such as NIBS Technical College (Wanjala & Were, 2019; KNBS, 2022). For young colleges that are still building their reputation and trying to stabilise their numbers, attracting students is hard, because applicants tend to go for names they already know.

To deal with this competition and raise their intake, the new colleges have started to use different marketing methods. Most of these methods, however, are used separately. Colleges visit high schools and attend career days, hang banners in their localities and are moving more and more to digital platforms, given the high use of mobile internet in the county (Communications Authority of Kenya, 2023). These efforts are rarely planned together. Broadcast media, and local vernacular radio in particular, is also under-used, even though it is one of the best ways of reaching the parents and guardians who usually pay the fees.

In spite of these activities, low enrolment remains a serious risk for the colleges. Recent monitoring and baseline data from the Ministry of Education's State Department for TVET show this clearly (Ministry of Education, 2025). The problem does not seem to be a lack of marketing. Instead, the continued shortfall points to poor coordination between the different communication channels. This study therefore looks at the influence of an Integrated Marketing Communications (IMC) framework, made up of digital marketing, broadcast media, outdoor media and experiential outreach, on student enrolment in these new colleges. The data collected in October 2025 give the following numbers.

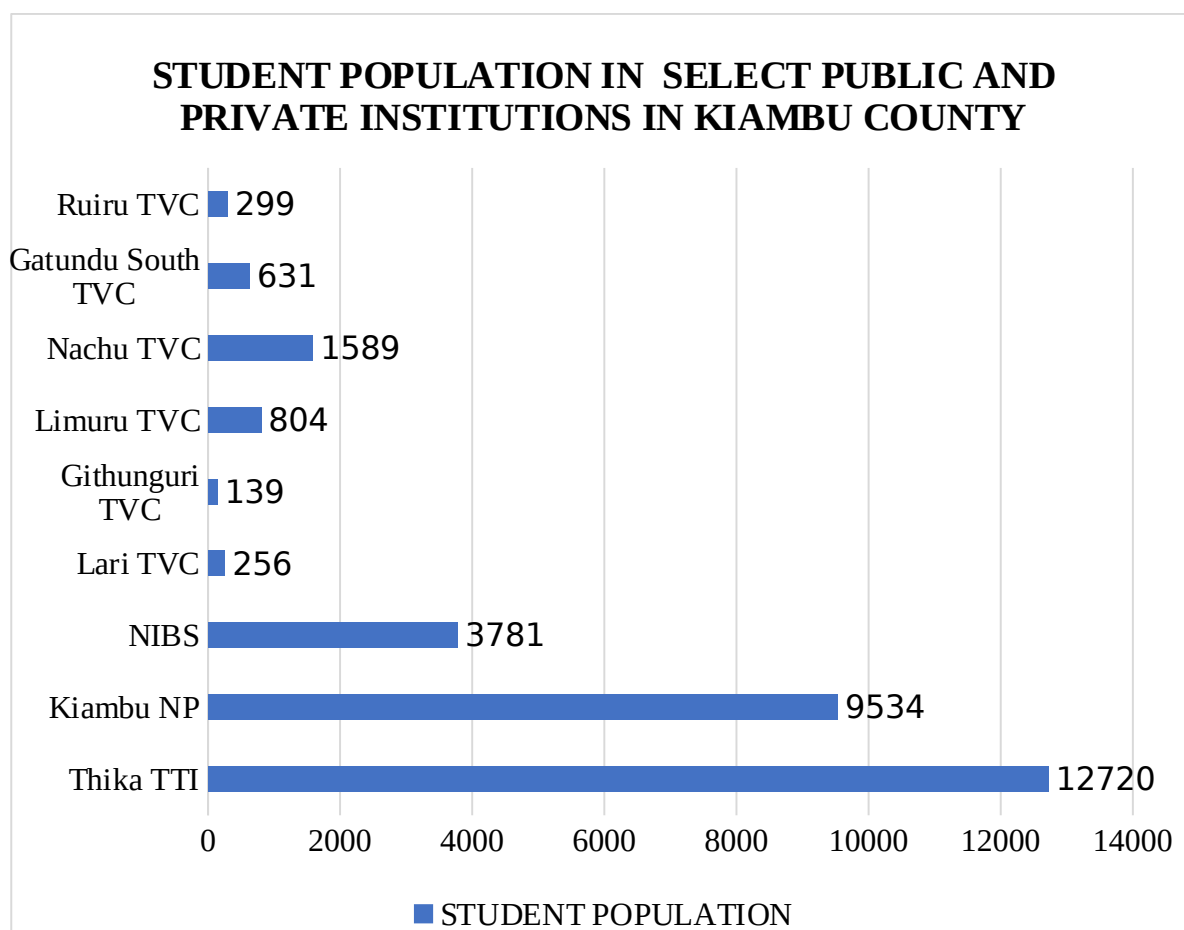


Figure 1 Enrollment Rates in Select TVET Institutions in Kiambu Source: Ministry of Education

The newly established Technical and Vocational Colleges (TVCs) in Kiambu County serve important local communities, but their enrolment is low compared with the county's larger and older institutions. Student numbers in the TVCs range from just 139 at Githunguri TVC to 1,589 at Nachu TVC. The older institutions are much bigger: NIBS has 3,781 students, Kiambu National Polytechnic has 9,534 and Thika Technical Training Institute has 12,720. This shows how far the new colleges lag behind the county's main training centres in attracting students.

Part of the problem is that there is little clear evidence on how these channels work together, or which combinations bring in the most students. Many of the new colleges spend money on digital marketing, broadcast media, outdoor media and outreach at the same time, without knowing how well these efforts fit together or how cost-effective they are overall (Kotler & Keller, 2016). This scattered approach tends to waste limited funds, send mixed messages and miss chances to recruit more students.

Without local evidence on how the four channels support one another, principals and registrars cannot make well-informed decisions on how to plan and divide their marketing budgets (Chaffey & Ellis-Chadwick, 2019). As a result, low enrolment continues, putting the financial future of the new colleges at risk and weakening the large public investment that the state has made in TVET.

TVET is central to Kenya’s industrialisation plans and to Vision 2030. Its success, however, depends on more than good policies and buildings; it also depends on how clearly and consistently colleges explain their value to the public. When training opportunities and modular CBET courses are not communicated in a clear and visible way, prospective students and their sponsors do not get to know about them. This adds to the mismatch between the skills being produced and those employers need, which in turn feeds youth unemployment and slows economic growth in the region.

It is against this background that the present study seeks to evaluate the influence of Integrated Marketing Communications on student enrolment in newly established public TVET institutions in Kiambu County, Kenya, looking at the separate and combined effects of digital marketing, broadcast media, outdoor media and experiential outreach. By producing local evidence, the study hopes to give practical guidance on how the colleges can coordinate their marketing, use their resources better and grow their enrolment steadily.

1.2 Statement of the Problem

Ideally, TVET institutions should attract large numbers of students by showing clearly how their courses give learners practical, industry-relevant skills. With policy support under Kenya Vision 2030 and a clear legal framework in the TVET Act 2013, Kenyan TVET institutions are expected to lead in industrialisation, innovation and youth employment. If this were the case, the government’s heavy spending on buildings, modern equipment and new institutions would result in high enrolment, full use of facilities and a steady flow of skilled graduates into the labour market.

What is happening on the ground is quite different, even though there are many potential TVET students in the county. In Kiambu County, KCSE candidates who score between C- (minus) and E are the main target group for TVET diploma, craft certificate and artisan courses. National examination results show that thousands of school leavers in the county fall into this group every year. Yet, even with this steady supply of potential students nearby, enrolment in local colleges remains low. The newly established colleges, namely Lari, Githunguri, Ruiru, Limuru, Gatundu South and Nachu Technical and Vocational Colleges, are still well below capacity. Ministry of Education guidelines require a TVC to have at least 1,500 students by its third year of operation, as the figure below shows:

Table 3 : National Government TVET Enrollment Targets

Classification National Government public TVETs	Annual trainee Enrolment Intake Target per year	Total Trainee Target (Overall Headcount)
National Polytechnic	3,000 – 6,000	10,000 – 18,000

Technical Training Institutes and Institutes of Science and Technology	2,000 – 5,000	8,000 – 15,000
Technical and Vocational Colleges (TVC)	500 – 1,500	1,500 – 4,000

Of the colleges in this study, only Nachu TVC has reached this minimum. The others, though opened at about the same time, are still far behind. Even Nachu, which has been running for five years, is only just at the minimum. Part of the reason is likely to be the old belief that vocational education is for students who miss a university place, which leads many families to overlook its value. At the same time, the new colleges face strong competition from older public institutions such as Thika Technical Training Institute and Kiambu National Polytechnic, and from active private colleges such as NIBS Technical College, all of which are well known and trusted.

To change this and attract local KCSE candidates, college managers have used several promotional methods. These include digital marketing (social media, WhatsApp groups and websites), mass media advertising (local radio and television), outdoor branding (billboards and gate branding) and direct outreach (roadshows, school visits and career days). These activities show that the colleges are trying to raise their profile, but they are usually carried out separately and not as part of a coordinated Integrated Marketing Communications (IMC) plan. As a result, the messages are scattered and do little to move prospective students from first hearing about a college to actually joining it.

The problem, then, is not just low enrolment in the face of a large pool of eligible KCSE candidates. It is also that little is known about how each IMC channel, and the channels together, affect students' decisions to enrol. Most earlier studies look at traditional or digital marketing on its own, and mostly in large companies or established universities. Hardly any have looked at how digital, broadcast, outdoor and experiential strategies work together in newly established public TVET colleges with limited resources. These colleges have been running for between three and eight years, as the table below shows:

Table 4 Operational timelines of Newly established TVETs in Kiambu County

Institution and Location	Year of Establishment	Key Operational Milestones
Nachu TVC (Kikuyu)	2018	Admitted its pioneer batch of trainees in July 2018.
Gatundu South TVC (Gatundu)	2019	Groundwork completed under the constituency TVET drive; began receiving official KUCCPS student placements

		in 2019
Lari TVC (<i>Lari</i>)	2019	Officially opened its doors and commenced academic operations in September 2019.
Limuru TVC (<i>Limuru Kamandura</i>)	2020	Registered under TVETA and opened for its pioneer student intake in 2020.
Githunguri TVC (<i>Githunguri Marige</i>)	2020	Fully operational since 2020
Ruiru TVC (<i>Ruiru</i>)	2023	Established under the expanded national TVET program; operational since 2023.

Without clear evidence on how well each channel works, and how well they work together, college managers are left to make costly guesses with scarce public money while modern training facilities remain under-used. This study seeks to fill that gap.

1.3 Objectives of the Study

1.3.1 General Objective

The general objective of this study is to investigate the influence of Integrated Marketing Communications on student enrolment in newly established public TVET institutions in Kiambu County, Kenya.

1.3.2 Specific Objectives

The study will be guided by the following specific objectives:

- To evaluate the influence of digital marketing strategies on student enrollment in newly established public TVET institutions.
- To assess the influence of broadcast media advertising on student enrollment in newly established public TVET institutions.
- To analyze the influence of outdoor media advertising on student enrollment in newly established public TVET institutions.
- To determine the influence of experiential outreach strategies on student enrollment in newly established public TVET institutions.

1.4 Research Questions

The study will be guided by the following research questions:

- What is the influence of digital marketing strategies on student enrollment in newly established public TVET institutions?
- What is the influence of broadcast media advertising on student enrollment in newly established public TVET institutions?
- What is the influence of outdoor media advertising on student enrollment in newly established public TVET institutions?
- What is the influence of experiential outreach strategies on student enrollment in newly established public TVET institutions?

1.5 Significance of the Study

The study is expected to benefit both policy and practice in Kenya's TVET sector in the following ways.

First, it will help principals and managers of newly established public TVET colleges, especially in Kiambu County. By showing how well a coordinated, multi-channel marketing approach works, the study will help them decide how to combine and share out their limited marketing budgets. Instead of relying on trial and error, they will be able to plan a coordinated marketing mix that raises enrolment and strengthens their institutions.

Secondly, the findings will be useful to policy makers in the Ministry of Education and in agencies that oversee TVET, such as the TVET Authority (TVETA) and the TVET Curriculum Development, Assessment and Certification Council (TVET CDACC). Under Kenya Vision 2030 and related plans, the government has spent heavily on new TVET institutions, expecting them to train large numbers of young people in competency-based skills. Low enrolment puts this spending at risk. The study will offer evidence that can guide national policies, strategic plans and common guidelines on student recruitment and branding in public TVET institutions.

Prospective students, parents and the wider community will also gain. By showing which channels carry information about TVET most effectively, the study can help to raise awareness and understanding of vocational education. This is important because TVET is still widely seen as a poor substitute for university. If colleges can explain their value clearly through digital, broadcast, outdoor and face-to-face channels working together, students and parents may begin to see the economic value of technical skills, which could lead to higher enrolment and better career choices.

The study will also add to academic knowledge. Although research on education marketing and student enrolment is growing, few studies have examined how Integrated Marketing Communications is applied, and with what results, in newly established public TVET institutions in Kenya. By filling this gap, the study will give future researchers a reference point on related topics such as institutional competitiveness, how students choose where to study and the role of promotion in the performance of public institutions.

Finally, the study has wider social and economic value. Higher enrolment in TVET institutions is not only good for individual colleges; it is closely linked to national development goals. A well-enrolled and well-run TVET sector helps to build a skilled workforce, reduce youth unemployment and narrow the gap between what schools produce and what industry needs. The results of this study should therefore support both the growth of the colleges and Kenya's long-term development plans.

1.6 Scope of the Study

This study looks at how Integrated Marketing Communications influence student enrolment in newly established public TVET institutions in Kiambu County, Kenya. It focuses on six new colleges: Lari, Githunguri, Ruiru, Limuru, Gatundu and Nachu Technical and Vocational Colleges. They make a good setting for the study because, although they have modern training facilities, they all find it hard to attract, enrol and keep students.

In terms of content, the study covers one independent variable, Integrated Marketing Communications (IMC), which is divided into four parts:

- Digital Marketing – social media activity, college websites, WhatsApp groups and online adverts.
- Broadcast Media Advertising – television adverts, spots on vernacular and national radio, and talk-show appearances.
- Outdoor Media Advertising – highway billboards, branding on college gates, roadside banners and flyers.
- Experiential Outreach Strategies – face-to-face activities such as career days, school visits, market roadshows and community baraza meetings.

The dependent variable is student enrolment, which will be measured through yearly registration trends, the courses students choose and the channels that led them to enrol. Other matters, such as student retention, academic performance and the quality of training, are left out so that the study stays focused.

Geographically, the study covers Kiambu County only. Its findings may offer lessons for other parts of Kenya where TVET is expanding, but they will be read within the Kiambu context, a

county with stiff competition among training institutions, wide reach of local media and good internet access.

In terms of time, the study will focus on marketing practices and enrolment trends between 2024 and 2026, so that the data reflect the conditions and policies that public TVET institutions in Kenya are working under today.

1.7 Operational Definition of Terms

1. Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET)

Education and training that gives learners the practical skills, knowledge and abilities needed for particular trades, jobs and careers. In this study, TVET refers to the public technical training sub-sector in Kiambu County that offers competency-based, skills-oriented courses.

2. Technical and Vocational College (TVC)

A public institution that offers technical and vocational training at artisan, certificate and diploma levels. In this study, TVCs are the six public colleges in Kiambu County being studied: Lari, Githunguri, Ruiru, Limuru, Gatundu and Nachu Technical and Vocational Colleges.

3. Integrated Marketing Communications (IMC) Framework

A planned approach in which several communication channels are managed together so that they give one clear and consistent message about a college's courses. In this study, IMC is made up of digital marketing, broadcast media, outdoor media and experiential outreach, which are assessed for their combined influence on enrolment.

4. Digital Marketing Strategies

The use of online platforms and digital tools to make a college visible, build its name and interact with prospective students. In this study, it covers college websites, search engine presence, social media (such as Facebook, TikTok and WhatsApp), online adverts, and bulk SMS or email.

5. Broadcast Media Strategies

The use of radio and television to spread promotional messages. In this study, it covers adverts, talk shows and features on national and local vernacular radio, and on mainstream or community television.

6. Outdoor Media Strategies

Physical advertising placed in busy public places so that a college stays visible in its area. In this study, it covers signboards, billboards, banners, posters and brochures in high-traffic parts of Kiambu County.

7. Experiential Outreach Strategies

Face-to-face promotional activities that let prospective students, and the people who influence them, see for themselves what TVET offers. In this study, it includes career days, visits to secondary schools, community awareness meetings, roadshows and caravans.

8. Student Enrollment

The process by which prospective learners formally register and join a technical institution, and the number who do so. In this study, it is measured by the applications received, the admissions made and the actual number of students registered in the selected TVCs each year.

9. Marketing Effectiveness

How far individual or combined communication strategies influence the decisions of prospective students. In this study, it is judged by students' awareness, the number of enquiries received and students' own accounts of how IMC channels affected their decision to enrol.

10. Perception of TVET

The attitudes, beliefs and opinions that students, parents and the community hold about the status, career value and quality of technical education. In this study, it refers to how these views shape the way people respond to a college's IMC campaigns.

11. Digital Engagement

How often and how closely prospective students interact with a TVC's online platforms. In this study, it is shown by actions such as time spent on the website, online enquiry forms submitted, direct messages sent, and likes, shares or comments on the college's social media pages.

12. Newly Established TVETs

TVET institutions set up by the National Government through the State Department for TVET within the last eight years. In this study, they are the colleges in Kiambu County that have been running for between three and eight years.

1.8 Limitations of the Study

Limitations are weaknesses or constraints outside the researcher's control that could affect the findings. The following are expected:

- ❖ **Self-Reporting and Recall Bias**
The study depends on what trainees and registrars report about which IMC channels (digital, broadcast, outdoor or experiential) influenced enrolment. Students may not remember accurately, or may give answers that seem more acceptable. To reduce this, the questionnaire will include related questions that allow answers to be cross-checked.
- ❖ **Administrative and Institutional Data Constraints**
Past enrolment figures and marketing budgets in the new colleges may not have been recorded consistently, since record-keeping is often weak in a college's early years. The researcher will therefore add official baseline reports from the Ministry of Education's State Department for TVET to the survey data.
- ❖ **Contextual and Environmental Dynamics**
Factors outside marketing, such as economic conditions that affect parents' ability to pay fees, delays in government funding (for example HELB or HEF processing) and changes in university entry grades, may also affect enrolment. The researcher will take these into account when interpreting and discussing the results.

1.9 Assumptions of the Study

Assumptions are conditions taken to be true, without proof, so that the study can go ahead. The study assumes the following:

- ✓ **Authenticity of Respondent Feedback**
That respondents, including TVC administrators, marketing officers and students, will answer honestly and accurately about their exposure to IMC channels and their reasons for enrolling.
- ✓ **Active Execution of IMC Tactics**
That all six colleges (Nachu, Lari, Githunguri, Ruiru, Limuru and Gatundu South TVCs) used at least two of the IMC channels (digital, broadcast, outdoor or experiential) during the 2024–2026 study period.
- ✓ **Stability of the Regulatory Environment**
That the rules governing admission to public TVET institutions, such as KUCCPS placement criteria and TVETA regulations, will stay fairly stable during data collection and analysis.
- ✓ **Sample Representativeness**

That the trainees and staff sampled from the six TVCs fairly represent the wider population of newly established public technical colleges in Kiambu County.

1.10 Delimitations of the Study

Delimitations are the boundaries that the researcher has chosen to set for the study. They are as follows:

- ❖ **Geographical and Institutional Scope**
The study covers only six newly established public Technical and Vocational Colleges in Kiambu County (Lari, Githunguri, Ruiru, Limuru, Gatundu South and Nachu TVCs). Older, well-established institutions (such as Kiambu National Polytechnic and Thika TTI) and private colleges (such as NIBS) are left out, so that the sample consists only of young public TVCs that have been running for three to eight years.
- ❖ **Conceptual Scope**
The study focuses on the Integrated Marketing Communications (IMC) framework, divided into four independent variables: Digital Marketing, Broadcast Media, Outdoor Media and Experiential Outreach. Other parts of the marketing mix, such as fees, the quality of physical facilities and course content, are outside its scope.
- ❖ **Dependent Variable Focus**
The study measures student enrolment, that is, the number of applications, intake trends and the channels that led students to enrol. Wider outcomes such as graduate employment, retention and academic performance are left out on purpose.
- ❖ **Temporal Scope**
The study covers promotional activities and enrolment trends between 2024 and 2026. Data from before 2024 will be used only as background.

CHAPTER TWO LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Introduction

This chapter reviews the literature on marketing communications and student enrolment in TVET institutions. It starts with the theories that guide the study, then looks at empirical studies on each IMC dimension, presents the conceptual framework and ends by pointing out the gaps that this study will address.

2.2 Theoretical Framework

Two theories guide this study: the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM) and the Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB). TAM helps to explain how prospective students respond to digital channels, while TPB helps to explain the social and personal factors that shape the choices of applicants and their families.

2.2.1 Technology Acceptance Model (TAM)

The Technology Acceptance Model was introduced by Fred Davis in 1989 and is still one of the most common frameworks for explaining how people come to accept and use new technology. TAM holds that a person's intention to use a technology, and their actual use of it, depend on two beliefs. The first is Perceived Usefulness (PU), which is how far the person believes the technology will help them reach their goals. The second is Perceived Ease of Use (PEOU), which is how little effort they expect it to take. When people find a platform both useful and easy to use, they develop a positive attitude towards it and are more likely to use it.

In education marketing, TAM helps to explain how prospective students behave online. If a college's website is cluttered, slow or difficult to use, students leave it before they learn anything about the quality of its training. In this study, TAM supports the Digital Marketing

variable. As the new public TVCs in Kiambu County build their social media pages, WhatsApp groups and websites, how easy and useful these platforms are will affect whether young people who are comfortable with technology complete their applications or turn to colleges with better online services.

2.2.2 Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB)

The Theory of Planned Behavior was developed by Icek Ajzen in 1991 to explain how the social setting shapes individual decisions. It holds that behaviour follows from intention, and that intention is shaped by three factors. These are attitude towards the behaviour (whether the person sees the action as good or bad), subjective norms (the pressure the person feels from important others such as parents, friends and community leaders) and perceived behavioural control (how able the person feels to carry out the action, given their resources and the obstacles they face).

TPB is useful for TVET marketing because the choice of where to study is always shaped by culture. In Kenya, vocational education has long carried a stigma, having been seen as the place for those who could not get a university place (Sifuna, 2020). This creates strong social pressure against TVET, which discourages even well-qualified students from enrolling, whatever training facilities may be available nearby.

This is why the non-digital parts of an IMC framework are important. Success stories of graduates shared on local radio can ease the money worries and doubts of parents, who usually decide whether fees will be paid. Career days and roadshows let prospective students and their families see real training equipment, showing in a practical way what TVET offers and who it is for.

2.3 Empirical Literature Review

2.3.1 Influence of Digital Marketing Strategies on Student Enrollment

Around the world, digital marketing has changed the way institutions recruit students. Many now use search engine optimisation, social media and email campaigns to attract applicants. Chaffey and Ellis-Chadwick (2019) note that digital marketing lets institutions target specific audiences and track results in detail, which traditional media cannot do. Constantinides and Stagno (2011) show that today's students treat an institution's online presence as their main source of information, and rely a great deal on reviews and interactive content when deciding where to study.

In developing countries, digital channels are growing fast, though they face some limits. In Ghana, Boateng and Okoe (2015) found that platforms such as Facebook and WhatsApp have become informal marketplaces where institutions deal directly with prospective students. In South Africa, Mpinganjira (2014) notes that digital platforms give new colleges a cheap and quick way of reaching many young people. However, poor internet connections, badly managed content and low digital skills often reduce the benefits of these investments.

In Kenya, the spread of smartphones and the internet has changed how education is marketed. Figures from the Communications Authority of Kenya (2026) show that most young Kenyans are active users of digital media, so online outreach has become essential for public institutions. Still, Kibet and Muturi (2020) found that many public institutions run poorly managed online platforms, with outdated websites and inactive social media accounts.

While these general trends are well known, there is little evidence on how new public TVET colleges in Kiambu County, such as Nachu or Lari TVCs, use targeted digital marketing to make up for their short history and attract students.

2.3.2 Influence of Broadcast Media Advertising on Student Enrollment

Advertising on television and radio helps an institution become widely known and earn public trust. Higher education institutions in many countries use broadcast campaigns to build their standing and make their names easy to remember. Hemsley-Brown and Oplatka (2015) note that broadcast adverts give institutions legitimacy and suggest stability and size to the public.

In Sub-Saharan Africa, broadcast media, and especially radio, is still a key source of local information. Maringe (2006) observes that where literacy levels vary, radio gets round the barrier of the written word and reaches several generations at the same time. In rural and peri-urban areas, radio carries a lot of social weight, and listeners often link an appearance on radio with official approval.

In Kenya, vernacular radio stations such as Kameme FM and Inooro FM, which are popular in the Central region, have strong cultural influence. Ngure (2013) notes that parents and community elders, who pay for most young people's education, rely heavily on vernacular radio for information they trust. Public TVETs sometimes use radio talk shows or short adverts during the admission season, but Wanjala and Were (2019) argue that these campaigns are seldom assessed to find out how much they actually add to enrolment.

There is therefore little knowledge of how new TVETs in Kiambu County can make planned use of broadcast media to reach the parents and guardians who decide where students will study.

2.3.3 Influence of Outdoor Media Advertising on Student Enrollment

Outdoor advertising, such as roadside billboards, banners and gate branding, gives a college a permanent presence in its area. Institutions in many countries use outdoor displays to mark their location and keep their names in people's minds along busy routes. Ivy (2008) notes that striking outdoor displays build familiarity over time and make an institution feel like a permanent part of the local scene.

In developing countries, outdoor branding matters most for new institutions that are not yet well known. Adewale et al. (2018) observe that well-placed billboards and a smart, clearly marked gate show the community that a new public institution is finished, equipped and officially open. On the other hand, an unmarked or badly kept gate can suggest neglect or even raise doubts about accreditation.

In Kenya, the number of public TVET facilities has grown fast, but many of the new colleges are away from the main roads in their sub-counties. Billboards along major Kiambu

roads, such as the Thika Superhighway and Limuru Road, and gate branding are used to show that the colleges exist, but their effect on enrolment has not been measured.

Most studies on education marketing focus on digital channels and say little about how local outdoor media affect the enrolment decisions of nearby communities. This study will look into that question.

2.3.4 Influence of Experiential Outreach Strategies on Student Enrollment

Experiential outreach covers face-to-face activities such as career days, open days, school visits and market roadshows, and it is the most personal form of education marketing. Kotler and Fox (1995) argue that personal contact is especially good at turning uncertain prospects into committed applicants, because questions can be answered on the spot and people can be reassured in person.

In developing countries, face-to-face marketing is an important way of building trust.

Oketch (2016) notes that in communities that have long doubted the value of technical training, bringing current students, trainers and equipment into public view helps to break down resistance. Such outreach moves the discussion from general descriptions to real, visible skills.

In Kenya, new technical colleges rely a lot on roadshows, visits to secondary schools and community barazas organised with local administrators. According to Ngure (2013), these events work well in challenging the “blue-collar stigma” because families can see modern training equipment for themselves. However, as Kibet and Muturi (2020) point out, such activities are rarely part of a wider, evidence-based plan and often happen as one-off events with no system for following up interested students.

Little is known about how such outreach, when coordinated with digital and media campaigns, leads to lasting increases in enrolment for new TVET colleges in Kiambu County.

2.3.5 Summary of Literature and Research Gaps

The global and local studies reviewed recognise the value of digital tools, broadcast media, outdoor signs and face-to-face community contact, but they treat these separately, and the literature remains fragmented. Most studies on education marketing deal with long-established universities or private colleges that have their own marketing departments, while very little attention has gone to new public TVET colleges with tight budgets. Local studies also tend to look at promotional methods one at a time, or simply compare traditional and digital methods.

There is a clear shortage of research that treats these channels as one Integrated Marketing Communications (IMC) system in Kenya’s vocational training sector. This study responds to that gap by assessing, in a local setting, how digital, broadcast, outdoor and experiential strategies together influence student enrolment in public TVET institutions in Kiambu County.

2.4 Conceptual Framework

The conceptual framework shows how the independent and dependent variables are expected to relate. The independent variables are the four parts of Integrated Marketing Communications (IMC): Digital Marketing, Broadcast Media Advertising, Outdoor Media Advertising and Experiential Outreach Strategies. The dependent variable is student enrolment in newly established public TVET institutions in Kiambu County, Kenya. The framework assumes that the way colleges coordinate and use these channels affects how aware prospective students are, how they view TVET and, finally, whether they decide to register.

The four parts of the IMC framework each contribute to enrolment in their own way, and they support one another. Digital Marketing reaches young people through websites and mobile platforms. Broadcast Media Advertising reaches the wider public, including parents and guardians, through radio and television. Outdoor Media Advertising makes the college visible in its locality through signs and billboards. Experiential Outreach Strategies bring college staff face to face with prospective students and help turn interest into a decision to join.

The dependent variable, Student Enrollment, reflects the combined result of these efforts across the six colleges.

The framework also assumes that the four channels have a greater effect when used together than when used separately. For example, a prospective student may first notice a billboard on the Thika Superhighway, later hear a feature about the college on Kameme FM with a parent, then attend a career day at school, and finally apply through a WhatsApp link. Each contact supports the others, and it is the combination of all four that moves the student from simply knowing about the college to actually enrolling.

2.5 Operationalization of Study Variables

Table 5: Operationalization Matrix

Sn.	Specific Objective	Independent Variable	Indicators	Measurement Scale	Statistical Analysis
1.	To evaluate the influence of digital marketing strategies on student enrollment	Digital Marketing	Social media frequency; Website usability; WhatsApp/SMS tracking; Online inquiry response times	Ordinal (5-Point Likert Scale)	Descriptive stats, Correlation, Regression
2.	To assess the influence of	Broadcast	Radio airtime frequency; TV spot	Ordinal (5-Point Likert	Descriptive stats, Correlation,

	broadcast media advertising on student enrollment	Media	placements; Audio-visual feature profiles; Estimated audience reach	Scale)	Regression
3.	To analyze the influence of outdoor media advertising on student enrollment	Outdoor Media	Highway billboard presence; Gate branding quality; Banner placement density; Brochure distribution footprint	Ordinal (5-Point Likert Scale)	Descriptive stats, Correlation, Regression
4.	To determine the influence of experiential outreach on student enrollment	Experiential Outreach	Career day participation; High school circuits; Market roadshows/caravans; Grassroots community barazas	Ordinal (5-Point Likert Scale)	Descriptive stats, Correlation, Regression
(Applies across all objectives)	Unified Outcome Dimension	Student Enrollment	Annual application volumes; Actual admissions numbers; Course enrollment distribution; Self-reported primary intake trigger	Ratio (Administrative registration counts)	Frequencies, Percentages, Means, Pearson Correlation, Multiple Linear Regression

Chapter Three: Research Methodology

3.1 Introduction

This chapter explains how the study will be carried out. It describes the research design, the target population, the sampling approach, the data collection instruments and the methods of analysis. It also sets out the steps that will be taken to ensure the quality of the data and to protect respondents.

3.2 Research Design

The study will use a descriptive survey research design. This design suits the purpose of the study because it allows the researcher to observe and record a situation as it is, in this case how students and staff see and respond to college marketing activities, without changing anything.

Because it collects data from several colleges at one point in time, the descriptive survey will help to answer questions about what marketing channels students were exposed to, where and how they influenced enrolment. It will also support the correlation and regression analysis needed to go beyond description and examine the relationships between the variables.

3.3 Target Population

The target population is made up of two groups in the six newly established public TVCs in Kiambu County: students and administrative staff.

Administrative staff, that is principals, marketing officers and admissions staff, are included because they plan and carry out the marketing being studied. They can explain how IMC channels are used in practice, the difficulties the colleges face and how well the methods seem to work from the college's side.

Students are included because the marketing is aimed at them. They are best placed to explain what actually led them to enrol, and their answers will show what is working and what is not from the students' side.

Each college is assumed to have one principal and about four marketing and admissions officers. Student numbers are estimated from available college records at about 100 to 110 students per college. This gives an estimated total population of 654 respondents across the six colleges.

Table 6: Target Population by Institution

Institution	Principals	Marketing/Admissions Officers	Students	Total
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Lari TVC	1	4	104	109
Githunguri TVC	1	4	105	110
Ruiru TVC	1	4	104	109
Limuru TVC	1	4	103	108
Gatundu TVC	1	4	104	109
Nachu TVC	1	4	104	109
Total	6	24	624	654

This population is suitable because it covers both what the colleges are doing to attract students and how students respond. Looking at both sides will make the findings fuller and more reliable, since the researcher can compare the colleges' efforts with the way students see and act on them.

3.4 Sampling Design and Techniques

3.4.1 Sampling Frame

For students, the sampling frame will be the official enrolment registers kept by the registrar's office in each of the six colleges for the current academic year. For administrative staff, it will be the staff lists of personnel assigned to admissions, marketing and community outreach.

3.4.2 Sample Size Determination

The student sample size will be calculated using Yamane's formula for finite populations, with a margin of error of five per cent. This will give a sample large enough for multiple regression analysis without making data collection unnecessarily large.

For administrative staff, a census will be used, and every eligible admissions and marketing officer in the six colleges will be invited to take part. Because this group is small, a census removes sampling error and captures the full range of staff views.

3.4.3 Sampling Technique

To make sure each college is properly represented, students will be stratified by college, with each of the six TVCs forming a stratum. The sample will be shared among the colleges in proportion to their size, so that the larger colleges do not outweigh the smaller ones. Within each college, students will be chosen by simple random sampling using computer-generated random numbers applied to the registration list, giving every student an equal chance of selection.

3.5 Data Collection Instruments

Primary data will be collected using structured questionnaires. Because every respondent answers the same questions in the same order, the answers can be compared statistically with confidence.

The questionnaires will use a 5-point Likert scale, from Strongly Disagree to Strongly Agree, which turns people's views and attitudes into numbers that can be analysed. The scale is widely used in education marketing research and fits the objectives of this study.

3.6 Data Collection Procedures

Data collection will follow clear steps. After the proposal has been cleared by the Mount Kenya University postgraduate board, the researcher will apply for a research permit from the National Commission for Science, Technology and Innovation (NACOSTI).

With these documents, the researcher will meet the principals of the six colleges to get permission to collect data. Questionnaires will be administered both online and by trained research assistants. Students will fill them in during scheduled class breaks, while administrative staff will use a drop-and-pick-later method so that they can respond without disrupting their work.

3.7 Pilot Testing

Before the main fieldwork, a pilot study will be carried out with a group of respondents equal to ten per cent of the total sample. It will take place in a public TVET institution in Nairobi County, away from the study colleges, so that the main respondents do not see the questionnaire in advance.

3.7.1 Validity of the Instruments

Content validity will be ensured by linking every questionnaire item to the study objectives, research questions and conceptual framework, so that none of the IMC channels is left out. Construct validity will be supported by basing all questions on TAM and TPB, so that ideas such as "digital engagement" and "marketing effectiveness" are expressed as practical, observable actions.

3.7.2 Reliability of the Instruments

The reliability of the questionnaire, meaning how consistent its results are, will be tested by calculating Cronbach's alpha (α) from the pilot data. A coefficient of 0.70 or higher is generally taken as reliable in social science research. Any item that lowers the reliability of its section will be reworded or removed before the final questionnaire is printed.

3.8 Data Analysis and Presentation

The completed questionnaires will be checked for completeness, coded and entered into the computer, and then analysed in two stages:

1. Descriptive Statistics

Frequencies, percentages, means and standard deviations will be used to summarise the data, describe the respondents and show how visible and influential each marketing channel is seen to be.

2. Inferential Statistics

This stage goes beyond description to test the relationships between the variables and to predict enrolment trends.

Pearson Correlation Analysis – This will show the direction and strength of the relationship between each IMC channel and student enrolment.

Multiple Linear Regression Analysis – This will be the main method of analysis. It will show how the four channels together influence enrolment, and its coefficients will indicate which channel contributes most.

Diagnostic Tests

Three diagnostic tests will be run before interpreting regression outputs

- **Normality Testing**
This will confirm that the data are normally distributed, which parametric tests require. It will be checked using statistical tests and normal probability plots.
- **Multicollinearity Testing** – This will confirm that the four independent variables are not too closely related to each other. If two channels are very highly correlated, their separate effects on enrolment cannot be told apart. The Variance Inflation Factor (VIF) will be used, and values well below the accepted limit will show that each channel adds its own information.
- **Linearity Testing** – Scatter plots will be used to check that the relationship between the marketing channels and enrolment is linear, as the regression model assumes.

3.9 Ethical Considerations

To protect the rights of respondents and uphold academic integrity, the study will observe the following ethical principles:

1. Informed Consent

Taking part will be voluntary. Before receiving a questionnaire, every respondent will be told the purpose of the study, and anyone may withdraw at any stage without penalty.

2. Anonymity and Confidentiality

To encourage honest answers, respondents will not be asked for their names, identity card numbers or any other identifying details. All data will be combined and reported only as overall figures.

3. Protection from Plagiarism

All literature, theories and secondary data used in the study will be properly cited, and the final document will be checked using the university's plagiarism detection software.

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APPENDIX I: RESEARCH QUESTIONNAIRES

QUESTIONNAIRE 1: FIRST-YEAR STUDENTS

Research Project Title

Influence of Integrated Marketing Communications on Student Enrollment in Newly Established Public TVET Institutions in Kiambu County, Kenya

Introduction & Consent Note

Dear Student,

This questionnaire is part of an academic research project that looks at how different marketing and communication channels (online platforms, radio and TV, billboards, and school visits and roadshows) influenced your decision to join this college.

Your participation is completely voluntary. Please do not write your name anywhere on this questionnaire. Your answers will be kept strictly confidential and used only for academic analysis. Thank you for your time and participation.

SECTION A: DEMOGRAPHIC INFORMATION

Kindly check (√) or fill out the appropriate option.

1. Indicate gender

☐ Male ☐ Female ☐ Prefer not to say

2. What is your current age bracket?

(Note: Age data is collected to evaluate how different marketing and communication channels appeal across distinct age groups).

☐ Under 20 years ☐ 20 – 24 years ☐ 25 – 29 years ☐ 30 years and above

3. Which institution are you currently enrolled in?

☐ Lari Technical and Vocational College

☐ Githunguri Technical and Vocational College

☐ Ruiru Technical and Vocational College

☐ Limuru Technical and Vocational College

☐ Gatundu South Technical and Vocational College

☐ Nachu Technical and Vocational College

4. What program level are you currently studying?

☐ Artisan Certificate ☐ Craft Certificate ☐ Diploma

SECTIONS B TO F: STUDY VARIABLES

Please indicate your level of agreement with each statement by ticking (√) the number that best reflects your view.

Scale: 1 = Strongly Disagree (SD) 2 = Disagree (D) 3 = Neutral (N) 4 = Agree

(A) 5 = Strongly Agree (SA)

Table 7: Study Variables

No.	Statement	1 (SD)	2 (D)	3 (N)	4 (A)	5 (SA)
B	DIGITAL MARKETING STRATEGIES					
1.	Social media platforms (e.g., Facebook, TikTok, WhatsApp) were my primary source of initial information about this college.					
2.	Information about courses and fees on the college website is clear and easy to understand.					
3.	The college website content is consistently kept up to date.					
4.	Text messages (SMS) from the college influenced my decision to submit an application.					
5.	Online interactions with the college digital pages increased my confidence in registering here.					
C	BROADCAST MEDIA ADVERTISING					
6.	Radio advertisements or talk shows on national or local stations raised my awareness of this college.					
7.	Television advertisements or news features showcasing campus facilities influenced my choice to enroll.					
8.	Broadcast media convinced me that TVET courses lead to viable career opportunities.					
9.	Radio information played a major role in convincing my parents or sponsors to support my studies here.					
D	OUTDOOR MEDIA ADVERTISING					
10.	Directional signboards along highways helped me locate the physical campus.					
11.	Highway billboards made the college recognizable to prospective students.					
12.	Banners and posters in market centers effectively highlighted upcoming intake dates.					

13.	Printed brochures and flyers provided helpful details about admission requirements.					
14.	Physical branding on campus gates and walls creates a professional image.					
E	EXPERIENTIAL OUTREACH STRATEGIES					
15.	High school career day visits by college representatives generated my initial interest in technical training.					
16.	Community roadshows and caravans helped clarify my doubts about vocational education.					
17.	Direct interaction with college representatives at community gatherings motivated me to join.					
18.	Live skill demonstrations during public events made technical courses appealing to me.					
F	STUDENT ENROLLMENT DECISION					
19.	Promotional activities directly prompted my decision to submit an admission application.					
20.	Institutional marketing materials positively shifted my perception of TVET education.					
21.	Overall, I am satisfied with my enrollment decision based on the information communicated to me.					

QUESTIONNAIRE 2: ADMINISTRATIVE & MARKETING STAFF

Research Project Title

Influence of Integrated Marketing Communications on Student Enrollment in Newly Established Public TVET Institutions in Kiambu County, Kenya

Introduction & Consent Note

Dear Respondent,

This questionnaire forms part of an MBA research project assessing the operational integration and effectiveness of corporate communications in driving enrollment trends within public TVET institutions.

Because of your role in the college, your experience is very valuable to this study. Your identity will remain anonymous, and all information will be reported only in combined form. Thank you for your cooperation.

SECTION A: BACKGROUND PROFILE

Kindly check (√) or fill out the appropriate option.

1. What is your specific department or role?
☐ Admissions Office
☐ Registry / Academic Affairs
☐ Public Relations / Marketing Committee
☐ Other (Please specify): _____

2. How long have you worked within the TVET sub-sector?
☐ Less than 2 years
☐ 2 – 5 years
☐ Above 5 years

3. Name of your current station/institution:
☐ Lari Technical and Vocational College
☐ Githunguri Technical and Vocational College
☐ Ruiru Technical and Vocational College
☐ Limuru Technical and Vocational College
☐ Gatundu South Technical and Vocational College
☐ Nachu Technical and Vocational College

SECTIONS B TO F: INSTITUTIONAL MARKETING METRICS

Please indicate your level of agreement with the following statements regarding your institution's practices.

Scale: 1 = Strongly Disagree (SD) | 2 = Disagree (D) | 3 = Neutral (N) | 4 = Agree (A) | 5 = Strongly Agree (SA)

Table 8: Institutional Marketing Metrics

No.	Statement	1 (SD)	2 (D)	3 (N)	4 (A)	5 (SA)
B	DIGITAL MARKETING EXECUTION					
1.	The institution allocates adequate budgetary resources for digital marketing activities.					

2.	Social media platforms are updated frequently to engage prospective applicants.					
3.	Online application portals are functional and streamline the admissions process.					
4.	Bulk SMS messaging is used effectively to follow up on prospective student inquiries.					
C	BROADCAST MEDIA MARKETING					
5.	Local vernacular radio stations are utilized to reach parents and sponsors.					
6.	Radio broadcasts and talk shows are scheduled to align with key placement and intake periods.					
7.	Budgetary constraints restrict the institution ability to run television advertising campaigns.					
D	OUTDOOR MEDIA IMPLEMENTATION					
8.	Directional signboards and banners are strategically placed across major market centers.					
9.	Print materials (flyers and brochures) are regularly distributed to build local awareness.					
10.	Physical campus branding updates have enhanced the institution image in the community.					
E	EXPERIENTIAL OUTREACH ACTIONS					
11.	Management prioritizes school visits to recruit completing secondary school students.					
12.	Interactive roadshows and caravans lead to immediate increases in student inquiries.					
13.	Direct face-to-face engagement is an effective strategy for addressing cultural stigmas against TVET.					
F	MARKETING FRAMEWORK & ENROLLMENT OUTCOMES					
14.	Promotional campaigns are typically run as standalone activities rather than as a synchronized IMC effort.					

15.	The institution lacks empirical data on which communication channel yields the highest recruitment return.					
16.	A fully integrated, multi-channel marketing campaign correlates directly with increased student intake.					

SECTION G: OPEN-ENDED ADMINISTRATIVE INSIGHTS

Kindly provide brief descriptive answers based on your practical experience at this institution.

In your opinion, which single communication channel or outreach strategy generates the highest volume of actual student enrollments at your college? Briefly explain why.

What primary challenge does your institution face when coordinating digital marketing activities?

What primary challenge does your institution face when executing physical outreach and broadcast campaigns?

Thank you for supporting this research project!